

Slow versus Fast running

Q: I have been trying to improve my health and fitness by running as often as I can. I don't know, though, which is better: running at a slow pace for a long time or running at a fast pace for short time. Which one will help me more in terms of getting my heart and lungs into shape?

A: For heart and lungs and general fitness, running at a gentle pace will get you in good shape. Running faster and shorter will get you in better shape for racing. I recommend mixing the two in an organized training program, but there's no reason why anyone has to run any faster than he wants to if the main goal is fitness.

In determining which style is "better", one consideration is calorie burn. Frequently, people interested in losing weight ask whether fast or slow running burns the most calories. The speed at which you run doesn't matter. Rather, the distance you cover determines how many calories you burn.

Here's how the arithmetic works: An average person who weighs 150 pounds burns 100 calories per mile. (Weigh more or less and you'll burn slightly more or less, depending on your weight.) If you run 3 miles, whether fast or slow, you'll burn 300 calories. In fact, if you walk the same number of miles, you'll still burn that many calories. Calorie burn relates to foot pounds: how many pounds you push across so many feet of ground. Other sports such as swimming or cycling have different calorie-burn rates, but walking and running are approximately the same.

Fast running has somewhat of an advantage over slow running or walking because you can burn more calories in a shorter time. If you walk at a speed of 3 mph (20:00-mile pace), you'll burn 300 calories. But if you run

at a speed of 6 mph (10:00-mile pace), you can burn 600 calories in the same hour's time. Run 10 mph (6:00-mile pace) and you can burn 1,000 calories. But if you run at that same fast 6:00-mile pace and only go 3 miles, your calorie burn is 300. But is one pace better than another? It depends on your personal goals.

There are other reasons why you may want to run fast or slow. Many runners get in a rut of covering the same distance at the same pace day after day. Eventually, they plateau and never improve. That is why advanced runners include slow, long runs in their weekly training schedules – and sometimes fast, long runs. As you progress as a runner, you will be able to determine which training paces and which training distances work best for you on different days.

Rest

Q: I am a 44-year-old male. It seems that if I run every day, I do not recover enough to feel strong. How many rest days should I take per week? What is your advice on the amount of training days, and the intensity of the workouts, for a man my age?

A: It really varies from person to person. When I was your age, I sometimes trained twice a day, up to 100 miles a week, to get ready for the World Veterans' Athletics Championships. But I don't necessarily recommend that routine for everybody, nor could I maintain that level of training today in my sixties.

For some runners, a day where they run an hour at an easy pace qualifies as "rest". Others need total rest: no running. And maybe two days of rest. Everything is relative to your own level of fitness and motivation. Having said that, I would suggest that for runners serious about their training, two or three days of running easy, coupled with one or two days of rest. That doesn't necessarily add up to a week, but people differ in their abilities to absorb training and in how much rest they need between hard sessions.

Calorie Burn

Q: I am 20 years old. I want to start running and go on a diet to lose 40 pounds. How many minutes do I have to run to lose weight?

A: It's not so much a matter of minutes; it's miles.

A person who weighs about 150 pounds burns 100 calories for every mile covered running. Someone who weighs more (or less) will burn more (or fewer) calories, but 100 is a handy number to work with in explaining calorie burn.

One pound equals to 3,500 calories. Eat 3,500 calories worth of food, and you'll gain 1 pound. Burn 3,500 calories exercising, and you'll lose 1 pound. Given that figure, you need to run 35 miles to lose 1 pound, 350 miles to lose 10 pounds, and 1,400 miles to lose 40 pounds. Averaging 27 miles a week, it would take you one year to lose 40 pounds. That much mileage may sound intimidating to a beginner, but it's about what the average reader of *Runner's World* magazine runs weekly.

You don't necessarily need to run nearly 4 miles a day to lose weight. You can combine diet with exercise. You can eat less. In fact, running often has the effect of at least temporarily suppressing your hunger. You also can't snack on chocolate chip cookies while running. Some people snack out of boredom, and running has the capability of filling boring times of the day. If running motivates you to cut even 250 calories from your daily diet (those chocolate chip cookies), that would be the equivalent of 2.5 miles running.

You want to create a calorie deficit. The combination of 250 calories dieting and 250 calories running would create a calorie deficit of 500 calories

daily, or 3,500 calories a week. Voila, you've just lost 1 pound.

That's theory, of course, and weight loss is not always as easy to achieve in practice, nor is it easy to maintain that weight loss. Maintaining weight loss will require a permanent lifestyle change. I can't promise that you will lose 40 pounds because of your new running routine, but you certainly will be choosing the correct strategy if you can combine diet and exercise.

You're probably going to find that the first 10 to 20 pounds will roll off relatively easy, assuming that you definitely are overweight. Once you have achieved your early weight loss, it will get progressively tougher as the body fights to preserve a certain percentage of fat for good health. Another conundrum is that the lighter you get, the fewer calories you will burn running, because you will have less weight to impede you.